

Women's Safety as an Internal Security Imperative

Epigraph

*"The degree of **civilisation** in a society can be judged by entering its prisons; the degree of its **security** can be judged by how safely its women walk its streets."*

Introduction

Women's safety is not merely a law-and-order concern but a core **internal security** challenge because pervasive gender-based violence erodes social cohesion, delegitimises the State, and normalises impunity. Rising crimes against women, despite an expanding legal architecture, signal deep structural distortions in India's security, governance and cultural matrix.[1][2]

The stakes are existential: a nation that cannot guarantee bodily integrity and dignity to half its citizens cannot credibly claim internal stability or institutional legitimacy.

Why Women's Safety is an Internal Security Issue

Scale and Pattern of Violence

NCRB data show **4.48 lakh cases of crimes against women in 2023**, with cruelty by husband/relatives (1.14 lakh), kidnapping, sexual assault, and rape forming the bulk of offences.[1][2] This represents a **0.7% increase from 2022**, signalling a persistent epidemic:

- Approximately **one crime every 2 minutes** against women
- Cruelty by intimates and relatives accounts for **25.4%** of all crimes
- Rape cases: **31,382 in 2023** (underreporting remains endemic)
- Kidnapping: **40,000+ cases annually**, many driven by caste and communal motivations[3]

Such *endemic* violence creates an atmosphere of chronic **insecurity** that is functionally indistinguishable from low-intensity internal conflict in its psychological impact on half the population.[1]

Erosion of State Legitimacy and Rule of Law

Persistent under-reporting, delays in FIRs, low conviction rates (approximately **27% for rape cases**) and victim-blaming convey a message of **institutional apathy**, weakening citizens' trust in the criminal justice system.[2][4]

High-profile cases—from Jyoti Singh (2012) to Prabhakaran case (2024)—repeatedly exposing police inaction or complicity deepen perceptions of a **patriarchal bias** in law-

enforcement, undermining the normative authority of the State.[4][5] When women view the police as complicit rather than protective, the social contract fractures.

Social Cohesion and Communal Tension

Sexual violence has been weaponised in communal and caste conflicts, turning women's bodies into sites of collective humiliation and revenge, thereby aggravating **identity-based** fault lines.[2][4]

Targeted attacks on women from marginalised groups (Dalits, Adivasis, religious minorities) can trigger riots, vigilante justice and cycles of retaliatory violence. During the 2002 Gujarat riots and more recent communal tensions, sexual violence served as a deliberate strategy of subjugation.[3][5]

Multi-Dimensional Analysis

1. Socio-Cultural Dimension

Patriarchal Norms and Gender Socialisation

Deep-rooted **patriarchy**, son preference, and honour-based notions of family prestige normalise control over women's mobility, sexuality and choices, legitimising everyday violence.[1][4] The concept of female chastity as "family honour" transforms women into property rather than autonomous citizens.

Stereotypical portrayals of women in media and popular culture reinforce objectification and trivialisation of harassment, weakening societal deterrence.[6] Victim-blaming narratives—questioning what women wore, where they went, or whom they met—perpetuate impunity and shift accountability away from perpetrators.

Intersectionality and Vulnerability

Poor, migrant, Dalit, Adivasi and disabled women face a "**triple burden**" of gender, caste/class and location, making them more exposed to trafficking, workplace abuse and custodial violence.[2][4] In rural areas, women face dual control: patriarchal household structures AND weak state presence.

Conflict zones (Kashmir, Northeast states), urban slums and disaster-affected areas become spaces of heightened **gendered insecurity**, with weak oversight and informal power structures enabling impunity.[7][2]

2. Legal-Institutional Dimension

Expanding but Under-Enforced Legal Framework

India has enacted a dense architecture:

- Criminal Law (Amendment) Acts post-Nirbhaya (2013)
- Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (2005)
- Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act (2013)
- Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act (2012)[8][6]

Despite stronger laws and the **Justice Verma Committee** recommendations (2013), gaps persist in implementation, victim-friendly procedures, and witness protection.[6][8]

Policing and Criminal Justice Deficits

Inadequate women's representation in police (only **9-12% in many states**), lack of gender-sensitive training, and overburdened investigators delay and dilute justice, weakening deterrence.[9][6] Many police stations lack dedicated women's cells or female constables, forcing women to file complaints before male officers.

Poor forensics, hostile cross-examination, and slow trials contribute to low conviction rates, producing a climate of de facto **impunity** for offenders.[3][2] Acquittal rates in rape cases exceed **70%** in some jurisdictions due to weak evidence handling and victim intimidation.

3. Governance and Policy Dimension

Fragmented Implementation Architecture

Multiple schemes aim to create integrated response:

1. **Nirbhaya Fund** (₹1,000 crore corpus): Safe cities, fast-track courts, awareness programmes[10]
2. **Umbrella Scheme on Safety of Women**: Integrated approach across ministries[11]
3. **Women Safety Division** in MHA: Coordinating policy and implementation[12]
4. **One Stop Centres**: Victim support and counselling (400+ operational)[13]
5. **Universal Women Helpline (1090)**: 24/7 emergency redressal[13]
6. **Safe City Projects**: 20 cities with CCTV, street lighting, emergency response[9]

However, **74% utilisation of Nirbhaya Fund** (as of December 2024) indicates delays and capacity constraints.[14] Inter-departmental coordination gaps and uneven state-level capacities blunt impact on ground-level **security outcomes**. [12][14][10]

Urban Planning and Infrastructure Deficits

Poor lighting, unsafe public transport, deserted last-mile connectivity, and unregulated informal spaces make cities "**hostile geographies**" for women, especially at night.[7][6] In many Indian metros, women restrict movement after dark, effectively surrendering freedom of mobility.

Absence of gender-sensitive urban design undermines the ideal of **inclusive cities** and restricts women's participation in economic and political life.[7] Safe City projects must integrate lessons from international models (Seoul's women-only transport, Copenhagen's gender-sensitive urban design) adapted to Indian contexts.

4. Economic and Workplace Dimension

Labour Force Participation and Economic Security

Fear of harassment in public spaces and workplaces depresses **female labour force participation**, which at **32.8%** lags far behind male participation (78%).^{[8][7]} Many women are pushed into low-paid, informal, or home-based work, limiting economic mobility.

This perpetuates **economic disempowerment**, which reduces bargaining power within family and society, locking women into cycles of dependence and vulnerability.^{[4][1]} Economic independence is inseparable from bodily autonomy and freedom of movement.

Workplace Harassment and Productivity

Inadequate compliance with the Sexual Harassment Act, weak **Internal Committees** (per POSH Act), and retaliation against complainants deter reporting of workplace abuse.^[8] Many women suffer in silence rather than face ostracism or dismissal.

The resulting **hostile work environment** lowers productivity, increases attrition, and constrains the demographic dividend by excluding educated women from formal sectors.^{[7][8]}

5. Technological and Cyber-Security Dimension

Cyber-Violence and Online Radicalisation of Misogyny

Cyberstalking, non-consensual circulation of intimate images, deepfakes, and coordinated trolling have created a pervasive layer of **digital insecurity** for women.^{[5][2]} A 2023 survey found **42% of Indian women** experience online harassment.

Online spaces often incubate aggressive misogyny, reinforcing offline violence and deterring women from full participation in the digital public sphere.^{[2][7]} Incel forums, coordinated harassment campaigns, and "revenge porn" networks operate with near-total impunity.

Law-Enforcement Capacity in Cyberspace

While initiatives like the **Cyber Crime Portal** and tracking systems for sexual offences exist, police capacity in digital forensics and cross-jurisdictional cooperation remains inadequate.^{[13][12]} Most state police cyber wings lack trained personnel and modern tools.

Slow takedown of harmful content and weak platform accountability embolden perpetrators and normalise **virtual impunity**.^{[5][2]}

6. Internal Security, Extremism and Border-Security Linkages

Trafficking, Organised Crime and Terrorism

Women are trafficked for forced labour, sexual exploitation and forced marriages by organised criminal networks, often using porous borders and conflict-affected regions.^{[15][2]} An estimated **2.4 million persons** are in conditions of forced labour in South Asia; women constitute the majority.

Such networks intersect with drug smuggling, arms trafficking and, at times, **terror financing**, directly impacting national security.^{[13][15]} Human trafficking funds militant

operations, creating direct nexus between gender violence and terrorism.

Conflict Zones and Custodial Spaces

In areas affected by insurgency, communal riots or caste conflicts, women face heightened risk of sexual violence by both state and non-state actors, weaponising gender for political ends.[15][4] Kashmir, the Northeast, and Maoist-affected zones witness systematic abuse by security forces and insurgents alike.

Abuse in prisons, shelter homes or police custody not only violates human rights but also fuels alienation, grievances and international criticism of India's **rights record**. [15][2] Custodial rape and torture of women detainees remain chronic problems in several states.

Causal Chain: Women's Safety and Internal Security

The following flowchart illustrates how gender-based insecurity cascades into institutional and national security crises:

Women's Safety Crisis
⇒
Erosion of State Trust
⇒
Delegitimisation of Law Enforcement
⇒
Social Unrest & Identity-based Mobilisation
⇒
Organised Crime / Extremist Narratives
⇒
Internal Security Weakening

Illustration of cascade mechanism:

Stage	Manifestation	Security Impact
1. Violence Endemic	4.48 lakh crimes annually; low prosecution	Citizens lose freedom of movement
2. State Apathy	Delayed FIRs, victim-blaming by police	Trust in institutions erodes
3. Delegitimisation	Women view police as complicit	Rupture of social contract
4. Grievance Accumulation	Alienation among marginalised women	Fertile ground for mobilisation
5. Organised Response	Vigilante justice, caste/communal riots	Non-state actors gain legitimacy
6. National Insecurity	Terror financing via trafficking, destabilisation	Sovereignty and stability threatened

Way Forward: Securing Women, Strengthening the State

A. Preventive and Structural Reforms

Cultural and Educational Transformation

Transform school curricula, media regulation and community programmes to challenge **patriarchal** norms and promote gender-equitable masculinities.[6][1] Curriculum must integrate consent, bodily autonomy, and respectful relationships from primary education onwards.

Mandatory gender-sensitivity modules for all frontline officials—police, judges, healthcare providers—to dismantle victim-blaming and patriarchal assumptions embedded in institutional culture.

Gender-Sensitive Urban and Transport Planning

Adopt gender-sensitive urban and transport planning, with mandatory safety audits, safe last-mile connectivity, and inclusive digital surveillance with privacy safeguards.[12][7]

- Mandatory street lighting in all public spaces
 - Women-only transport coaches (Metro, buses) with panic buttons
 - Real-time GPS-enabled public transport tracking
 - Safe houses and shelters at strategic transit nodes
 - Community policing models centring women's safety concerns
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B. Policing, Justice and Institutional Strengthening

Criminal Justice System Overhaul

1. Increase women's representation in police (target: **40% by 2030**)[9][6]
2. Establish fast-track courts dedicated to sexual offence cases
3. Strengthen victim-witness protection programmes with relocation and financial support
4. Mandate gender-sensitisation training for all judges and prosecutors
5. Reduce case backlogs through enhanced infrastructure and judicial appointments

Nirbhaya Fund and Scheme Acceleration

Ensure **full utilisation of Nirbhaya Fund beyond current 74%**, strengthen the Women Safety Division in MHA, and institutionalise rigorous monitoring of schemes like One Stop Centres and women helplines.[11][10][9][13]

Establish quarterly performance audits, grievance redressal mechanisms, and state-level accountability for scheme implementation.

C. Cyber and Border-Security Measures

Digital Security and Platform Accountability

- Enhance cyber forensics capability within state police cyber wings
- Establish dedicated units to track NCII (non-consensual intimate images) and deepfakes
- Mandate platform regulation with takedown protocols for harmful content (<24 hours)
- International cooperation with Interpol, UNODC for trafficking and cyber-crime investigation
- Privacy-preserving digital surveillance in public spaces with transparent oversight

Anti-Trafficking and Counter-Terror Integration

Integrate gender-sensitive protocols into counter-trafficking, anti-terror, and border-management strategies, with specialised units and trained personnel.[13][15]

- Designated anti-trafficking cells in all districts with victim rehabilitation focus
 - Joint task forces with BSF/BGB to disrupt cross-border trafficking networks
 - Intelligence sharing to link trafficking proceeds to terror financing
 - Regional cooperation frameworks (SAARC, BIMSTEC) for coordinated action
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Conclusion

Women's safety is the **litmus test** of India's internal security: a State that cannot guarantee bodily integrity and dignity to half its citizens cannot credibly claim to be secure. The 4.48 lakh crimes annually, low conviction rates, and cyber-violence epidemic reveal systemic failure across legal, policing, governance, and cultural domains.

Moving from sporadic outrage to systemic transformation—legal, institutional, cultural and technological—is indispensable if India is to convert "*Nirbhaya*" from a memorial of tragedy into a lived reality of ***fearless citizenship*** for every woman. Security is not merely

the absence of violence; it is the presence of freedom, dignity, and equal participation in the nation's political, economic, and social life.

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